

LAKSHYA PROVIDES SAVING GRACE IN AN OTHERWISE LACKLUSTRE CAMPAIGN

Indian supporters were left praising Lakshya's fourth-place finish. The exit of Satwik and Chirag **proved to be the biggest shocker.** The elimination of Sindhu, Prannoy and the women's doubles pair was in keeping with their form, rather the lack of it.

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Paris 2024 is the first time in three editions of the Olympics that India failed to add a medal from badminton to its tally.

Notwithstanding Lakshya Sen's fourth-place finish and the surprise defeat of Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, the overall performance provided a crude reminder of how empty the Indian cabinet is.

In short, Lakshya's run partly made up for the shocking loss of Satwik-Chirag. The rest of the performances were as anticipated.

After all, barring Satwik and Chirag, no Indian badminton player had made news at this year's BWF Tour.

The gravity of India's poor showing could be gauged from Prakash Padukone's reaction soon after Lakshya lost the bronze medal match. The legendary shuttler, known for his now-characteristic soft responses whenever asked for his views on Indian badminton, spoke from the heart and asked players to take up more responsibility.

Travelling for the first time to the Summer Games as part of the support staff, Prakash did not hide his

disappointment. This came after his trainee Lakshya let eventual double Olympic gold medallist Denmark's Viktor Axelsen escape with deficits of 17-20 in the first game and 0-7 in the second game of the semifinals.

Even in the bronze medal match, Lakshya moved close to victory before faltering dramatically. He won the first game comfortably and led 8-3 in the second against Malaysia's Lee Zii Jia before squandering nine points in succession and thereafter the match.

Sindhu's periodic defeats, most of those to lower-ranked players, were an indication of her lack of form. In fact, since suffering a stress fracture on the left ankle during her 2022 Commonwealth Games gold-winning campaign, Sindhu's comeback after a five-month layoff has been far from impressive.

Here, 13th-ranked Sindhu lost, in the pre-quarterfinals, to the first higher-rated player she faced. The